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Refugee Circle Content Feedback

Qualitative Research

June 2025

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Context

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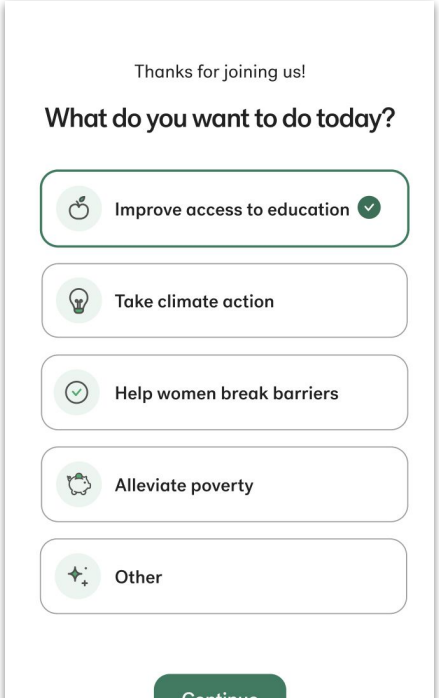
Strategic Themes: Reframe + Amplify Hypotheses

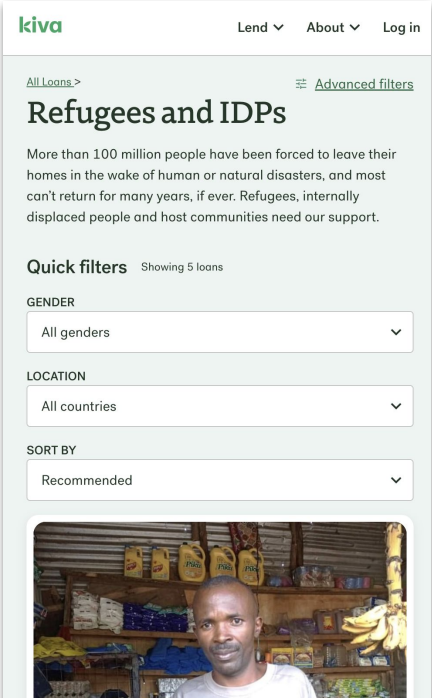
A new narrative hook combined with effortless giving can unlock deposits from audiences not yet on Kiva, underpinned by the same direct impact

Imagine that a prospective user clicks a refugee-related ad. We could...

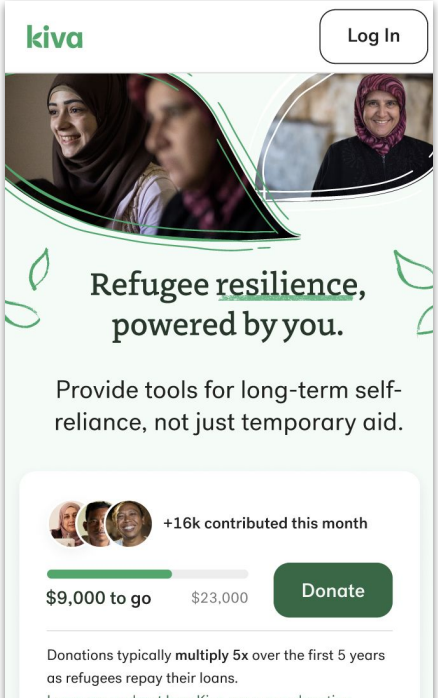
❌Pitch Kiva as a place to support any cause.



🤔Take them to a refugee loan-finding page.



🤔Explain our impact and make it easy to donate.



To be successful, we'll focus on testing with highly specific audiences with **strong impact alignment** and **outsized ability to give**.

- Wildfire-prone US cities
- Shoppers at B corps

I'm worried about **climate change**

- HBCU alumni
- Shoppers who buy local

I'm worried about **systemic inequality in the US**

- Diaspora communities
- Faith based givers

I'm worried about **the refugee crisis**

- Childless older women
- Women's affinity groups

I'm worried about **gender inequality**

Here's the specific focus for this research:

Can pages with a narrative about Kiva's refugee program (and no mention of loan choice) hook diaspora communities and faith-based givers?

Diaspora communities

Faith based givers

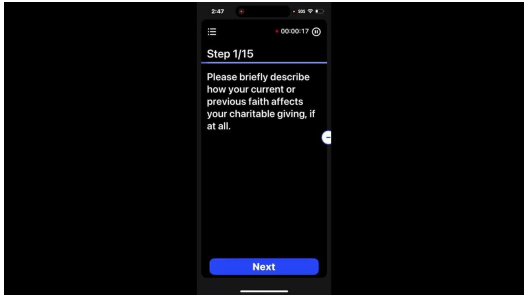
I'm worried about **the refugee crisis**

I will not donate unless I believe that:

✅ My money will be used in an impactful way

✅ The organization is trustworthy/ responsible with finances

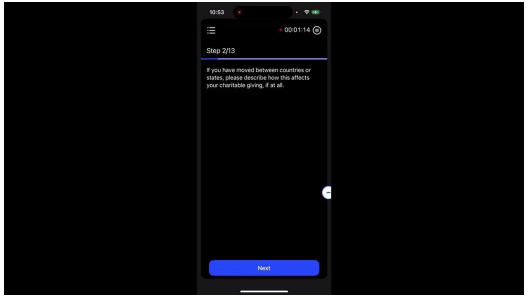
Faith-based givers



3+ faith-based givers saw each concept (15 total)

Many immigrants also described faith-based motivation.

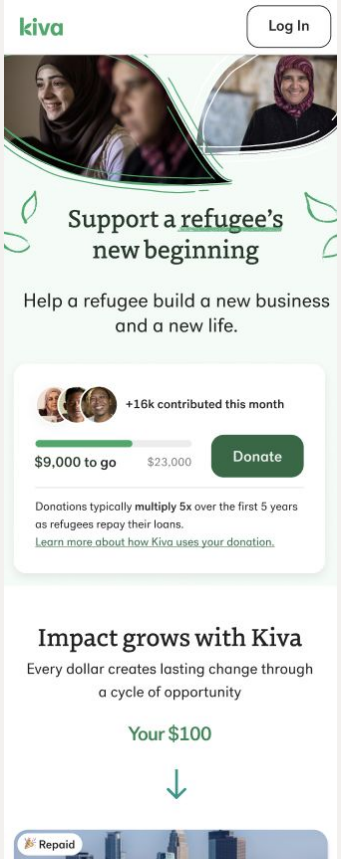
Immigrants

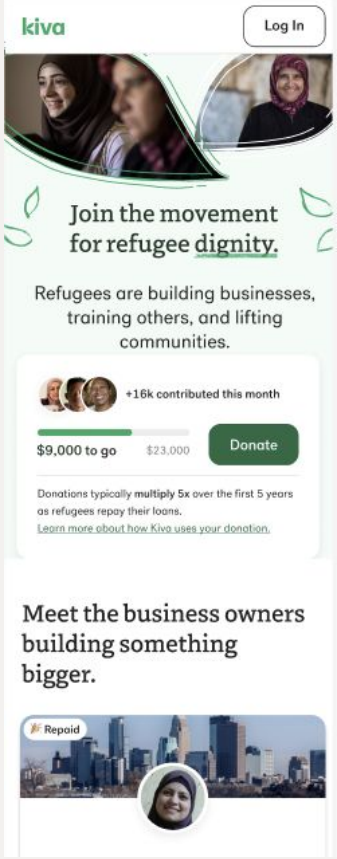


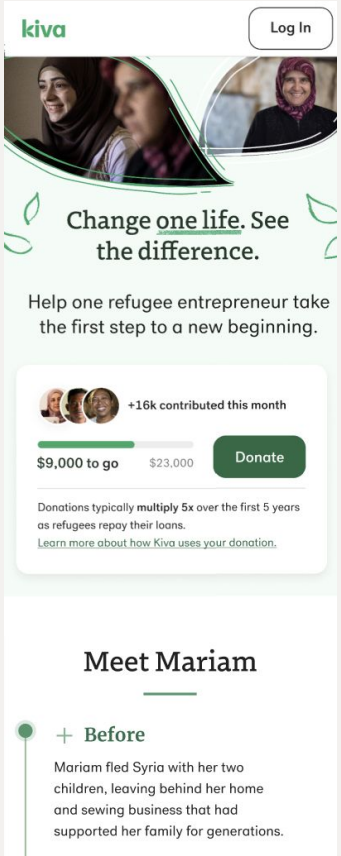
0-3 immigrants saw each concept (8 total)

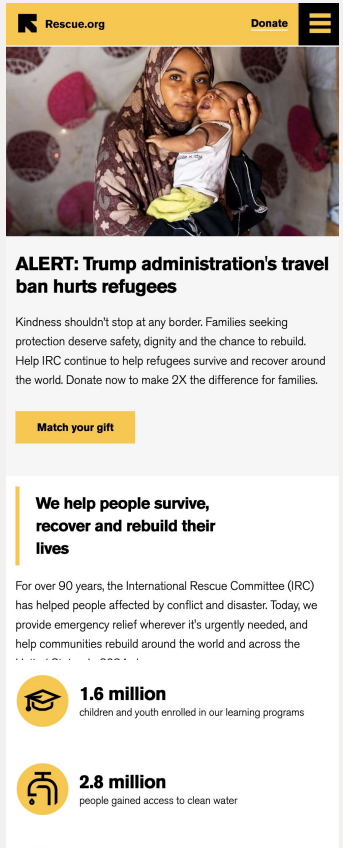
UserTesting was not able to fill all of the requests for the immigrant audience, even when I expanded to include: anyone living in the US who was born in another country outside of Europe, and who donated last year.

Designs used in research



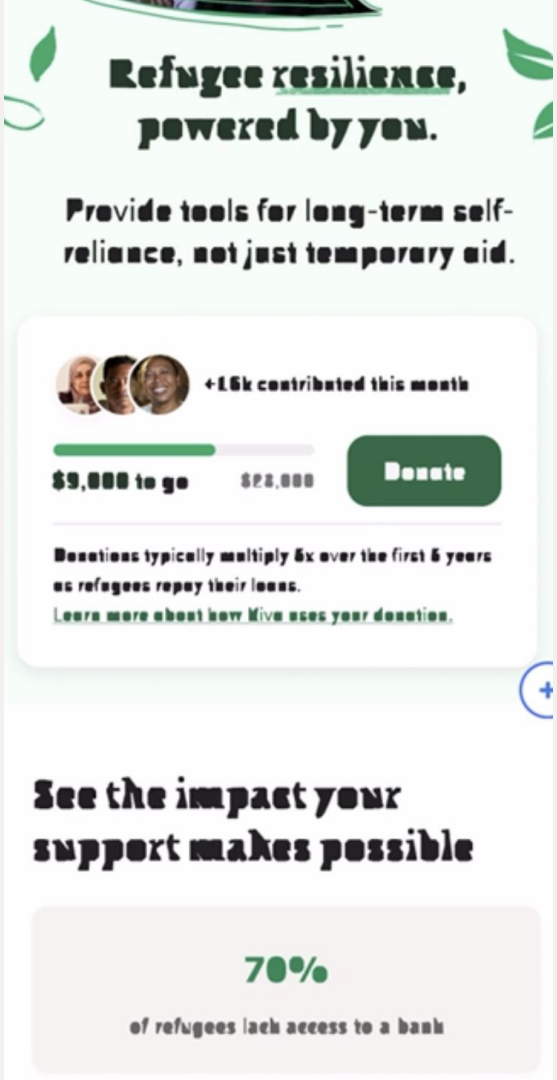






Technical Error

Some participants had a problem with the font not loading correctly.



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Overarching themes

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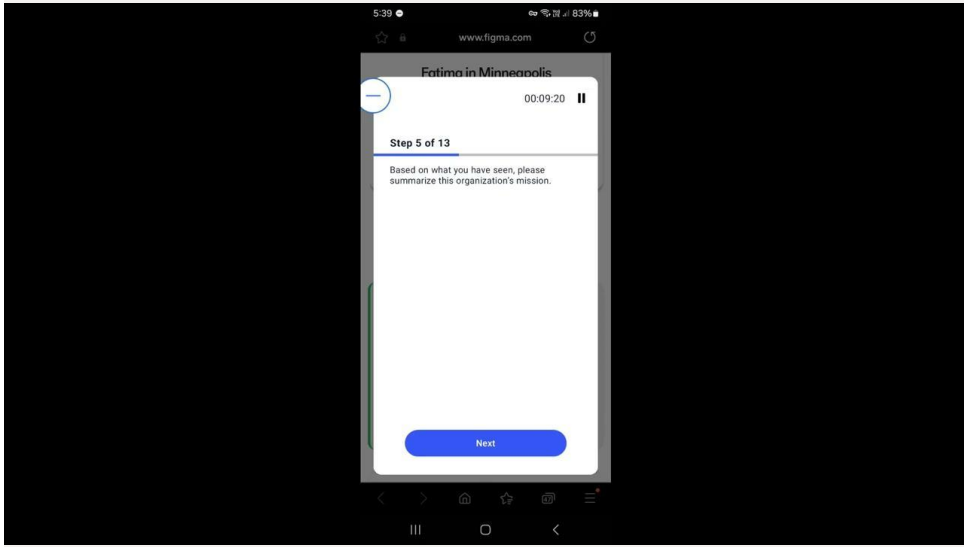
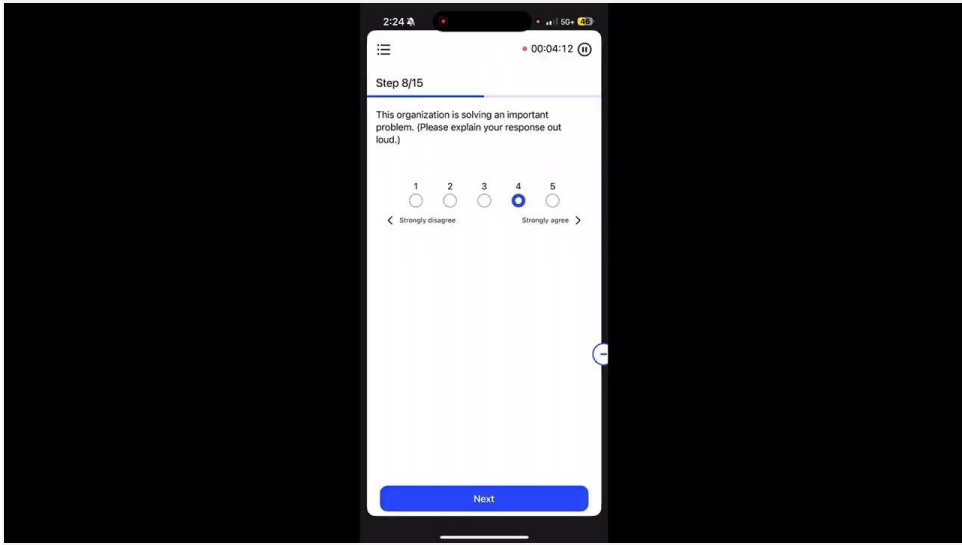
All of these pages helped users understand Kiva's mission and the problem we are solving when we lend to refugees.

Many still felt lingering questions, but they described us in a way that was accurate and uniquely Kiva.



Most participants said that Kiva was solving an important problem.

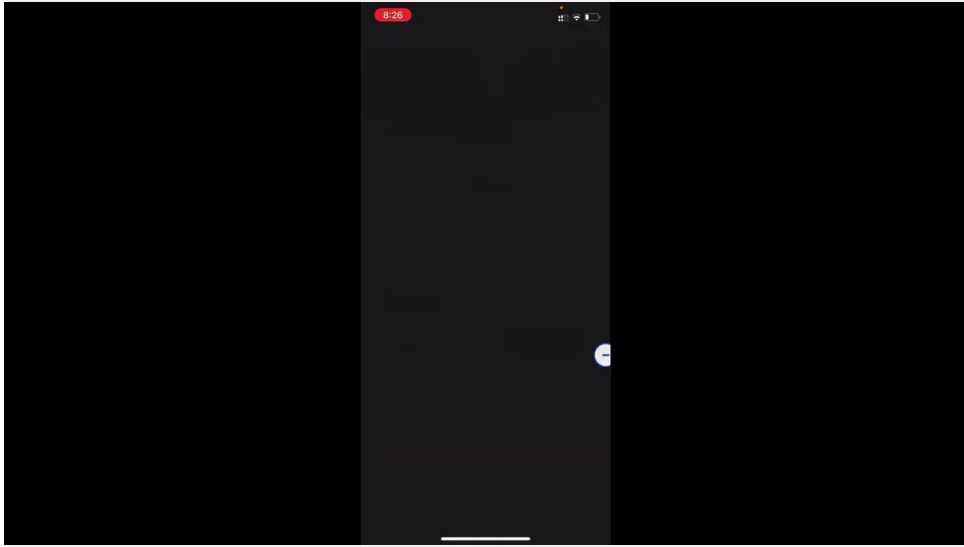
This is often a point of friction when testing existing Kiva content and landing pages.



When asked if Kiva was effective, participants pointed to borrower stories with a before and after.

Some also mentioned the value of re-lending, which was implicit in these stories. (Only 2 mentioned the repayments *statistic*.)

Relatively few raised questions about loan details - something which has been common in past research relying on text or diagrams to describe the idea of relending.



Other observations

Choice

These pages did not show any loan choice, and no participants asked for it. The simple donation ask met user expectations, and was not mentioned as a barrier to giving.

Transparency

The Charity Navigator rating (11), concrete stories (5), and other contributors / donation activity (2) were named as specific parts of the page that made it feel trustworthy.

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Feedback by concept

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One life

Not our stongest

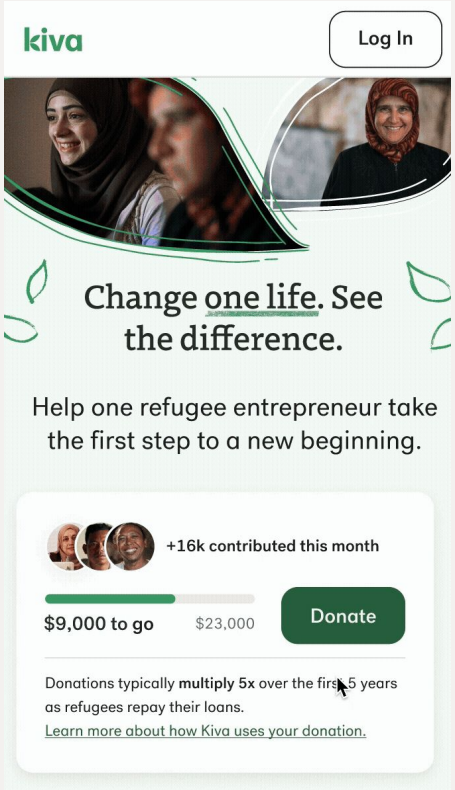
This version emphasized just 1 story, with no broader stats or mission.

Several people compared this page to other crowdfunding platforms. This was often tied to questions about *what fee* we were charging.

They described Kiva in a way that was mostly accurate and positive - but *felt* as if they didn't understand it.

The in-depth story on Miriam's before and after convinced participants that the organization was effective.

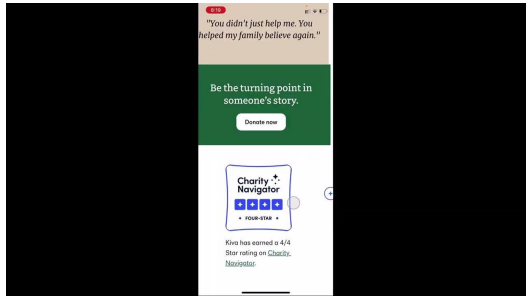
And yet, at the end of the session most people did *not* sound likely to support this organization.



They described Kiva in a way that felt mostly accurate and positive.

The in-depth before and after story made them believe Kiva was effective. One mentioned the “ripple effect” of repayment.

And yet, at the end of the session most people did *not* sound likely to support this organization.



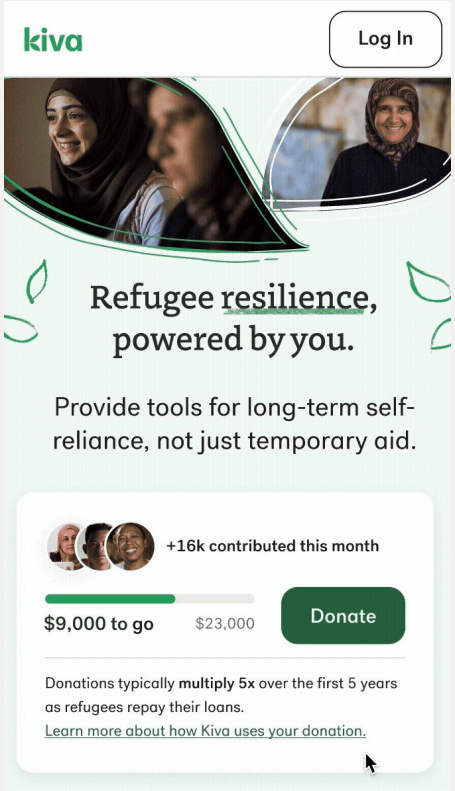
Resilience

Lukewarm

This version led with repayment stats and a narrative about financial inclusion. A borrower carousel followed.

Everyone who saw this page said they would need more information

No one said they were likely to donate

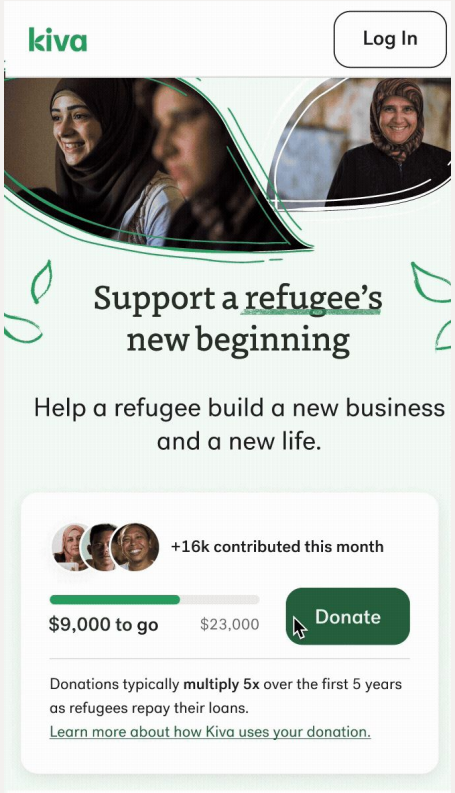


New beginning

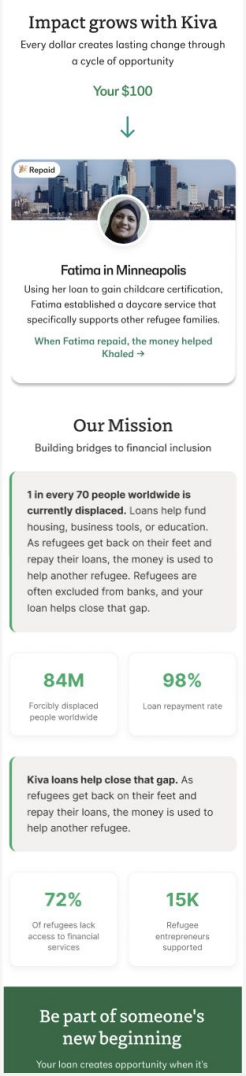
Lukewarm

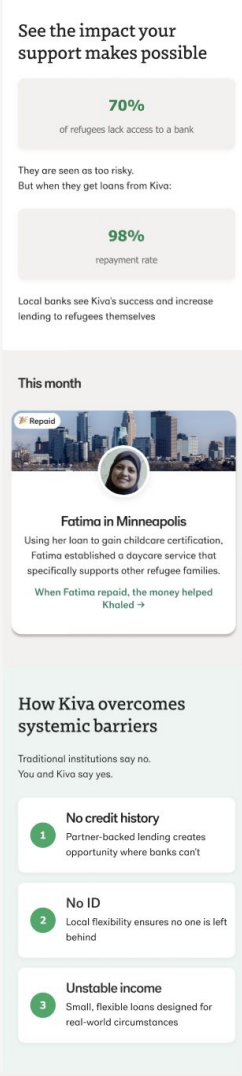
This version led with a borrower carousel and a headline about relending. A narrative about financial inclusion followed.

Reactions to the page were initially favorable *but* people walked away with questions that would prevent them from moving forward

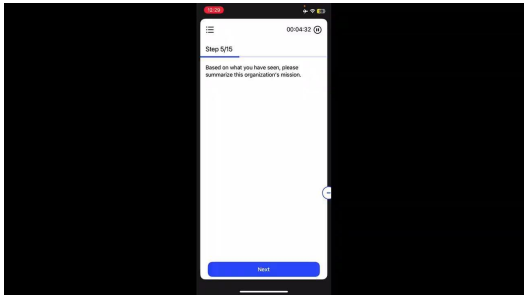


The financial inclusion narrative present in 2 of these concepts seemed to invite questions about loan terms and whether this could be harmful to borrowers.

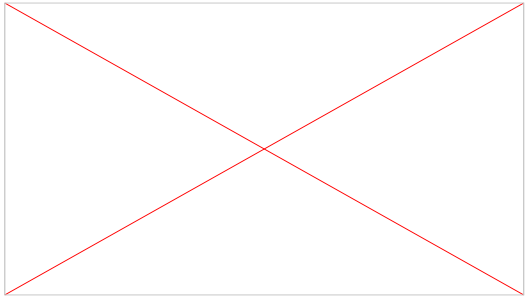




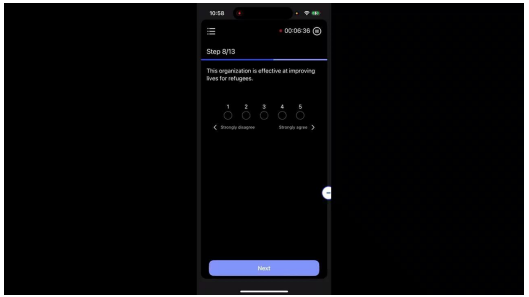
For immigrants, these pages spoke to a need they **already understood**



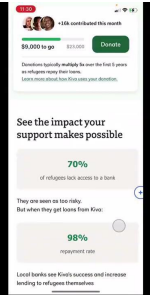
For faith-based givers, these pages helped them **get the problem for the first time**
Stats made the problem seem important



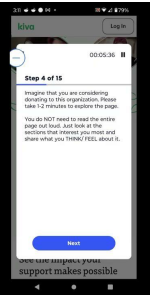
The financial angle prompted both to ask more questions about **potential borrower harm**



Stats made them believe the problem was important



Stories made them believe Kiva was effective



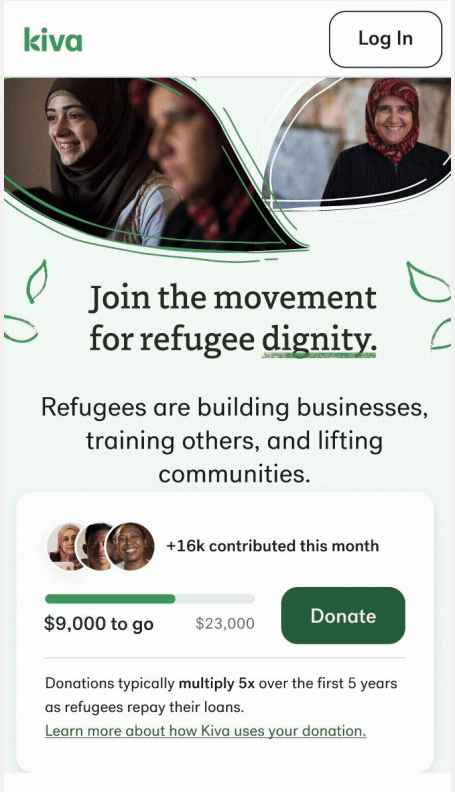
Dignity

Positive

This version focused on how refugees are hardworking and capable, with no mention of financial inclusion.

Best fit of any concept - participants rated it highly across the board and their descriptions **felt very close** to the way many lenders talk about Kiva.

One used the “teach a man to fish” analogy



3:49

Fatima in Minneapolis

From refugee to breadwinner, now hiring 2 others in her tailoring business.

Not donations.
Investments in real work.

Every borrower has a plan. Your loan helps make it real, then gets repaid and passed forward.

Agriculture

Construction

In their words

IRC

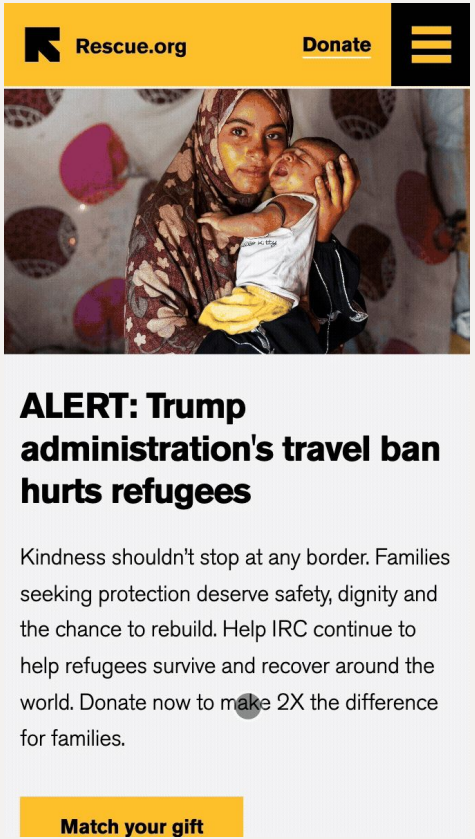
Positive

Overall, very positive

Did not get any feedback from diaspora communities

Some details that were mentioned

- 1 person appreciated the transparency into cost efficiency/ operating costs
- Blend of stats and stories was effective



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What now?

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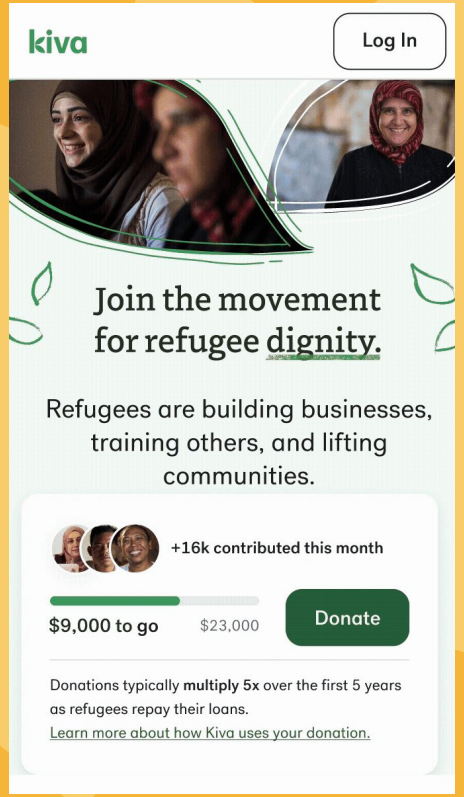
Top performer...



Join the movement for refugee dignity.

Refugees are building businesses, training others, and lifting communities.

Meet the business owners building something bigger.

Fatima in Minneapolis

From refugee to breadwinner, now hiring 2 others in her tailoring business.

"This loan was a vote of confidence."

This is what dignity looks like. Back it today.

Donate now

Not donations. Investments in real work.

Every borrower has a plan. Your loan helps make it real, then gets repaid and passed forward.

Agriculture

Construction

Ret

But could it be even better?

Moving forward, we could treat the ‘dignity’ page as the base case and get qualitative feedback on additional variations...

Test: Explain financial inclusion at the end... with reassurance for FAQs

Pull in this module or one of the others that zooms out to the big picture

How Kiva overcomes systemic barriers

Traditional institutions say no.
You and Kiva say yes.

1. **No credit history**
   Partner-backed lending creates opportunity where banks can't
2. **No ID**
   Local flexibility ensures no one is left behind
3. **Unstable income**
   Small, flexible loans designed for real-world circumstances

Our Mission

Building bridges to financial inclusion

1 in every 70 people worldwide is currently displaced. Loans help fund housing, business tools, or education. Refugees are often excluded from banks, and your loan helps close that gap.

84M
Forcibly displaced people worldwide

98%
Loan repayment rate

Kiva loans help close that gap. As refugees get back on their feet and repay their loans, the money is used to help another refugee.

"This loan was a vote of confidence."

Kiva removes barriers

70%
of refugees lack access to a bank

They are seen as too risky.
But when they get loans from Kiva:

98%
repayment rate

Local banks see Kiva's success and increase lending to refugees themselves

Kiva is committed to refugee success - even if that means some loans are not repaid. Loan terms are always favorable to borrowers.
Learn more

This is what dignity looks like. Back it today.

Be direct: Kiva is like a nonprofit bank, funded by you. Kiva uses the money donated by people like you to lend and re-lend to **people excluded from financial systems,** like refugees.

What if someone can't repay their loan?

Sometimes, a borrower is unable to repay their loan and that money is lost from Kiva's pool of funds to keep re-lending. We understand that some circumstances are beyond an individual's control and that this loss is an expected part of lending to at-risk communities.

Are loan rates favorable to borrowers?

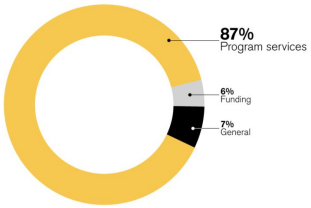
Kiva loans are issued through partners - local organizations working on the ground in the countries where borrowers live. Partners may charge low interest rates in accordance with the standards of their countries, but Kiva routines inspects partner practices to ensure rates are never predatory.

Test: Add program efficiency data

This module worked well for building trust on the IRC website

Our commitment to cost efficiency

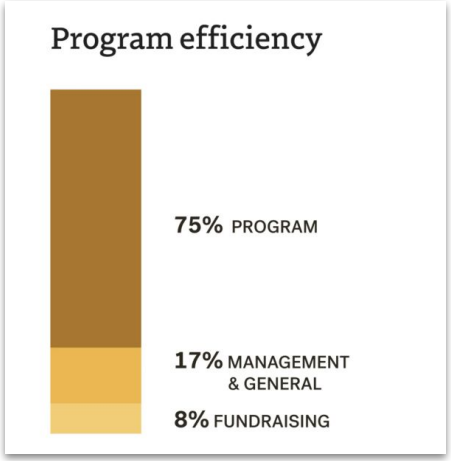
When you donate to the IRC, you're investing in an organization that prioritizes efficiency and effectiveness.



Our impact

With a 4-star rating and a 96% score from Charity Navigator, along with Candid's highest Platinum Seal of Transparency, we remain committed to maximizing the impact of every dollar.

We could try adding the version from our annual report, or create something new that explains the **fee structure** for Circles



Or, we could just launch a live test as soon as the Circles MLP is available.

The best test would be if we can unlock marketing resources to drive traffic from these audiences and see who converts. But even if we just use this as a swap for a current refugee promo CTA, we could start learning something.